

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world FluFrenzy

By David Bloom |

Human health has shown significant improvements during the past decade. Globally, life expectancy rose by 2.5 years. There was a major improvement in 210 countries, covering 98 per cent of the world's population. Most notably, the number of children who died before their fifth birthday dropped by 15 per cent, from 10.4 million in 2000 to below nine million this year. India has contributed to both the gains and outperforming the world: in the country, life expectancy increased by 3.1 years and the child mortality rate declined almost 27 per cent.

The world's health gains reflect the advances in medicine, improvements in nutrition and education, as well as a sharp rise in both private and public financial resources devoted to public health. Public health initiatives have also made strong contributions, the most notable being the advent of smoke-free spaces in 44 countries, a list in which India has been included too. The health improvements over the past decade have involved more than just adding years to life—they have added life to years. In other words, the onset of chronic disease and the functional breakdown of mind and body are being postponed too. And this increased healthy life expectancy is an extraordinary achievement. By defining what might be possible, it can—and should—make us even more ambitious about what can be achieved in the future.

On the other hand, notwithstanding the gains of the past decade, health of the global population is still not what it should be or could be. The world continues to deal with stubborn health challenges of the past, while it also faces new threats such as avian and swine flus, drug-resistant strains of existing microbes, environmental degradation, and a burgeoning incidence of chronic diseases. Significant failures in this arena indicate the extent and severity of human misery and insecurity that continue to persist on the planet. As one example, war and internal conflict have reversed a long history of life expectancy gains in Iraq, which has seen a nearly two-year decline in life expectancy this decade. As another example, the HIV/AIDS epidemics have erased decades' worth of gains in life expectancy in parts of

Africa. South Africa now has the unfortunate distinction of being the country with the largest number of people living with HIV (5.7 million), while Swaziland has the highest adult HIV prevalence (26 per cent). In the past decade, life expectancy has declined by nearly four years in both these countries.

To this list of deficits we can add the fact that 8.8 million children died in 2008, before celebrating their fifth birthday. This translates into, on an average, more than 24,000 child deaths every day (of which approximately 5,000 are Indian), and mostly from causes that can be prevented or treated through relatively cheap cures. For example, pneumonia, treatable with a Rs 27 dose of antibiotic syrup, accounts for almost one out of every five deaths of children under five each year. Diarrhoea, treatable with oral rehydration salts worth Rs 19, is the cause for 17 per cent of such



PLAGUED by Pandemics

Despite a rise in life expectancy, epidemics like swine flu and SARS prove that the world is fighting diseases that demand a cross-nation response

deaths. Underlying these health failures are deficits in health-related infrastructure, such as the fact that 1.1 billion people do not have access to clean drinking water, and 2.6 billion do not have access to sanitation, over one-fourth of which are Indian.

The new millennium has seen the emergence of new strains of influenza, including the H5N1 and H1N1 viruses. Malaria continues to kill one child every 30 seconds. Every day, 1,500 women die from pregnancy or childbirth-related complications, of whom nearly 400 are Indian. Neither India nor the world is on track to meet the Millennium Development Goals, all of which are linked to health, directly or indirectly. And because of the global economic crisis that began in 2008, redressing the

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- The flu frenzy began with SARS. First detected in China in 2002, it spread quickly to 37 countries.
- In 2006 came bird flu with a mortality rate of 60 per cent. Since its outbreak this year, swine flu has killed more than 4,500 people across 206 countries.